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GIVEN THAT MISHRA TOOK 7-106 IN HIS DEBUT TEST, CAPTAIN KUMBLE HAS TO RETURN AT THE VERY TOP OF HIS GAME.

NEW PUZZLE: Mishra celebrates a wicket, (right) Kumble will face increased scrutiny now

stump-seeking missile in Indian hands.

India are not surprised. At the pre-series camp the Indians believed Ponting's Australians were "certainly beatable". Captain Anil Kumble told INDIA TODAY, "After Bangalore, we were assured." In informal meetings before the camp, Sachin Tendulkar, Kumble and senior members of the Indian squad gathered in Bangalore to talk about plans for the series.

The choice of Amit Mishra as a third spinner over leggie Piyush Chawla and left-arm spinner Pragyan Ojha turned out to be smart. Not only does Mishra have 303 first-class wickets but also a big-turning leg-break, which helps set batsmen up for his googly and slider. Besides, the only footage of Mishra available to Australia came from a match versus New Zealand-A.

Once the contest began, the Indians thought on their feet and executed altered plans. After Ponting's Bangalore hundred, he was given nothing in Mohali that would allow him execute his most imposing backfoot shots, the cut and the pull. Instead, confronted by Ishant Sharma and his swing with new ball and old (not to mention bounce in the hair-do), he lost his wicket to him three times out of four. When asked if any other bowler had been so much trouble, Ponting grimaced a little, "Harbhajan, probably."

When the theatre resumes, India will find itself trying to shake off the celebration and un-



tangle all that the perfection of Mohali has actually left tangled. Australia's disarray (*see box*) is the least of its concerns.

Asked if he had ever seen the Aussies look like this in all the five series he had played against them, Kumble said laconically, "I think it's got something to do with the way we played." In Mohali, the injured leg-spinner took pictures of India motoring away to victory. He had lent his oversized captain's blazer to Dhoni for the toss and gave his replacement Mishra his first India Test cap just before start of play. But it is on the field that he must lead, and when Delhi comes around, he will need not just his right shoulder but what it sends down too, to be at its best.

Given that Mishra took 7-106 @15.14 in his debut Test, Kumble has to return at the very top of his game. The 11 for Delhi is now a fiendish puzzle and even though it is not a new one in cricket, it contains a twist. The man returning is the captain and his stand-in was a bowler, a key component in the perfect match, who presented new questions to the tourists. Against any other team, it would not prove to be such a dilemma. Against Australia, even a recently-eviscerated Australia, it is the only argument. If Kumble does return—and he has said he will—someone else, mostly blameless, will have to go.

Several solutions are at hand. Drop the captaincy, Ian Chappell says to Kumble. Drop Mishra,